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Power Apps or Devin?

Internal tools for a 60-engineer fintech

For the VP of Engineering

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THE ANSWER

Build with Devin, as a gated migration.

The decision isn't the 3 tools you have.

It's the 10+ tools you haven't specified yet.

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WHAT POWER APPS REALLY SELLS

Speed × governance, repeated.

Speed

Building blocks ship a tool in days

Governance

SSO, roles, masking, audit, DLP: all configuration

Managed platform

Microsoft hosts, patches and certifies it

Where it runs out: custom logic · your own APIs · automated testing · scale

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HOW DEVIN HELPS: WHAT I BUILT

Built once. Inherited by every tool.

Real SSO

Roles come from identity-provider groups

Masked PII

Reveal needs a reason, and every view is audited

Approvals

No self-approval; 2 approvers over $1K

Audit

Append-only, written with every change

Prototype: one shared Python platform + rules file (AGENTS.md). Built in ~47 minutes.

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BEYOND THE BUILDING BLOCKS

Your riskiest workflow, not a form.

Provider times out → UNKNOWN → reconcile → never pays twice

Every business rule is a named test that runs on every PR.

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THE TOOL FACTORY

One paragraph in. A governed tool out.

6 / 8 min

Fresh Devin sessions,
prompt → PR with green CI

0

Code bugs found
in review

1

Review round each
before merge

Controls were inherited without being asked for. Review caught decisions nobody wrote down; that's the control point.

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HONEST ASSESSMENT

What's replicable, and what isn't.

Replicable with Devin

SSO and roles

Masking and audited reveal

Audit and approvals

Custom logic and your APIs

Not replicable

Ops staff editing tools themselves

Microsoft's hosting and certifications

Mobile / offline

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WHERE THE RISK LIES

You own the security surface.

AI-written code

Touches money and PII

Human review and rule tests are mandatory

Compliance

Pen test, encryption at rest

AML retention vs GDPR erasure

New vendor

Devin has code access

Vendor review; no real PII in sessions

Power Apps doesn't remove this either: Microsoft certifies the platform, not your apps.

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3-YEAR COST

Build is cheaper over 3 years.

$1.20M

Buy

Power Apps

$1.04M

Build

base case

$0.79M

Build

Devin does the upkeep

Year 1 costs ~$220K more to build. Build overtakes Buy around month 26.

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THE METRIC THAT MATTERS

Engineers needed, from year 2.

0.52

FTE

Buy

0.71

FTE

Build, half-time owner

0.36

FTE

Build, Devin does the upkeep

Base case favours Buy. If the owner only reviews Devin's PRs (~6 h/week), Build needs fewer engineers.

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RECOMMENDATION

Build, gated on real numbers.

Why build

Your next tools are custom

The licence scales with users

Devin cuts the engineers needed

What flips it to buy

Next 10 tools are simple forms

Licence under ~$185K

Ops staff build tools today

Nobody can own the platform

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NEXT STEPS

Prove it on your hardest tool.

Week 0

Licence breakdown

List of the next 10 tools

Card data? EU-regulated?

Weeks 1–6

Devin + 1 engineer

Harden the platform

Highest-value tool first, on real systems

Gate

Human hours per tool ≤ 20% of Power Apps estimate

Owner ≤ 0.25 FTE

No high-severity failures

Drop Power Apps at renewal only if the gate passes.

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IF YOU KEEP POWER APPS

Devin still fits.

Optimise the licence

Per-app or pay-as-you-go for light users

Up to ~$100K a year saved

Use Devin at the edges

Custom connectors, code components, Azure Functions

Where code is needed anyway